

The Spain blame game

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By SEBASTIAN STARCEVIC GO

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GOOD MORNING. This is Sebastian Starcevic, still holding down the Playbook fort.

In today's Playbook:

- Inside the EU's emergency meeting on Spain's migrant crisis.
- The Danube drought is causing an energy crisis in Hungary and Romania.
- Faces in the crowd: Kyriakos Mitsotakis, José Manuel Albares, Péter Magyar, Dubravka Šuica, Magnus Brunner, Christel Schaldemose, Antonio Tajani, Theo Francken, Fernando Grande-Marlaska, Carles Puigdemont and more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian preview today's emergency meeting of the EU's home affairs ministers to discuss the Ceuta crisis.

DRIVING THE DAY

SPAIN STANDS ITS GROUND: Madrid will today confront EU home affairs ministers over what it sees as the bloc's lack of solidarity over Ceuta, while Greece pushes for sweeping emergency powers to deal with future migration crises, Playbook has learned from diplomats.

Migration Commissioner Magnus Brunner will attend the informal videoconference of home affairs ministers, which begins at 10 a.m. His colleague, Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica, told Playbook: "We want to work together to manage migration in an orderly manner and combat smuggling networks who play a big role." Šuica called for "constant engagement, mutual trust and all sides taking responsibility."

Things might not go that smoothly. Spanish Foreign Minister José Manuel Albares has stressed that Madrid itself requested the talks because it wants to "remind all EU member states that without solidarity, there is no Europe." That's after several governments called for Spain to be suspended from the Schengen area and 22 EU countries signed a letter Saturday attacking Madrid's migration policies.

To set up today's meeting, EU ambassadors spoke for around two-and-a-half hours on Monday — and there were tense moments. Spain was asked to provide verification of its claims about how many migrants had already returned to Morocco, two EU diplomats told my colleague Zoya Sheftalovich. (Reuters reports that 3,000-5,000 migrants remain in Ceuta, putting enormous strain on local facilities.)

Madrid struck a "slightly bitter" tone when it criticized the reaction from fellow capitals, one of the diplomats said. A second EU diplomat said some countries felt Madrid had encouraged migrants to arrive by granting amnesty, adding the situation in Ceuta was "so dramatic" that it had injected fresh energy into the discussion about securing Europe's borders.

Mind your language: The Spanish ambassador also criticized some politicians for spreading false claims about the migrant amnesty program, pointing to Italian Foreign Minister Antonio Tajani's statement on social media, according to one of the EU diplomats. The program provided legal residency to eligible migrants but didn't automatically confer Spanish citizenship, as Tajani claimed.

Athens weighs in: Greek Prime Minister Kyriakos Mitsotakis is calling for "a dedicated EU emergency regime to temporarily suspend the lodging of asylum applications for newly arrived persons, while proceeding with the swift return of those not entitled to remain."

Mitsotakis argues in an op-ed for POLITICO that the Ceuta emergency is a reminder that migration can be used as a "tool of geopolitical coercion," while conceding that nobody knows what caused the border surge that left 72 people dead.

Spain's Interior Minister Fernando Grande-Marlaska will today argue his country was left without sufficient backing from its European partners in the Ceuta crisis' immediate aftermath and will present figures showing migrant arrivals to Spain fell by more than 40 percent in 2025.

Holdouts: Just four countries declined to sign Saturday's letter: Ireland (which holds the rotating Council presidency), France, Portugal and Luxembourg. A diplomat from one of those capitals said they objected because the letter failed to show sufficient solidarity with Spain and only inflamed the situation.

Lessons to learn: The meeting will give ministers their first chance to jointly examine what happened in Ceuta and will focus on what lessons the EU should draw, another European diplomat told Playbook.

The takeaway: The EU is still reckoning with what happened in Spain last week — but while some countries are pointing fingers, Madrid is refusing to take all the blame.

BIG AND BREAKING

ADIEU PALANTIR: Europe is hunting for alternatives to the American data analytics giant but they won't be easy to find, according to my colleagues Antoaneta Roussi, Emile Marzolf and Anouk Schlung.

ENERGY WARS: Ukraine and Russia are locked in a battle to smash each other's energy systems — and the campaign will define future peace talks, Ukraine's Deputy PM Denys Shmyhal told Veronika Melkozerova.

MADE IN EUROPE (SORT OF): EU governments want to slap a "Made in Europe" label on specific products from partner countries outside the bloc.

SEPARATISTS ON THE MOVE: The Catalan pro-independence party Junts (led by Carles Puigdemont) joined the European Democratic Party on Monday, moving one step closer to becoming a member of the

liberal Renew Europe group in the European Parliament, my colleague Max Grier writes in.

DANUBE DROUGHT

CRISIS ON THE DANUBE: As the Danube's water levels plunge amid a historic drought, countries on the river's banks are being forced to shut down their nuclear reactors and even use explosives to divert water in a desperate bid to keep the lights on.

In Hungary, one turbine of the Paks nuclear plant is still running, Prime Minister Péter Magyar announced Monday . But the record-low water levels of the Danube, which cools Paks' four reactors, could force a complete shutdown of the plant later this week.

Running on fumes: Paks generates around 40 percent of Hungary's electricity and Magyar on Monday warned that the country is entering its "five most difficult days." The government is boosting energy imports from EU countries and asking people and industry to use less electricity.

That works too: Meanwhile, Romania's naval forces used 180 kilograms of explosives to blast away a rock blocking the flow of water to the country's last working nuclear reactor at Cernavodă. Bucharest declared a nationwide state of emergency this month and is buying electricity from Ukraine.

Don't panic: A European Commission spokesperson said the EU executive is "closely monitoring the security of electricity supply situation" and "stands ready to convene" an emergency meeting of representatives from affected member countries. But it added that so far, Hungary, Romania and Bulgaria's markets are all coping.

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BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Mostly sunny and clear. High 31C.

IT'S HOT. AGAIN. If you're looking for some respite, Playbook recommends Barkboy next to Central Station, which sprawls out over three levels. Grab an iced dirty chai and head downstairs for a blast of AC and tables to work at (and try to spot your Playbook author). The XYZ cafe in Saint-Gilles also has co-working space and AC, my colleague Zoya says.

BOZAR EXHIBITION: Brussels' Centre for Fine Arts is hosting an exhibition about Western beauty standards, until Aug. 16.

BELGIAN MILITARY SERVICE FULLY BOOKED: Belgium's first voluntary military service intake is full, Defense Minister Theo Francken said Monday . The catch: There were only 500 spots, filled from more than 3,000 applicants. Eighty percent of recruits are men; 283 are Dutch-speaking and 217 French-speaking.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

London: Andy Burnham is facing the first major test of his premiership after announcing changes to Labour's controversial prisoner-release program.

Paris: A prominent Macron ally says centrist presidential hopefuls should steer clear of the Ceuta row — but Gabriel Attal isn't listening .

Washington PM: Donald Trump says Tehran is ready to make a deal on the Strait of Hormuz ... Tehran says they're not even talking ... and so the war of words goes on.

AGENDA

— EU home affairs ministers hold an extraordinary video conference at 10 a.m. to discuss developments in Ceuta. Migration Commissioner Magnus Brunner will then hold a press conference at 1 p.m. (watch live here).

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Christel Schaldemose; Italian Foreign Minister Antonio Tajani; Fredrik Reinfeldt, former prime minister of Sweden; former European Commissioner Jutta Urpilainen; former Spanish PM José Luis Rodríguez Zapatero; POLITICO's Graham Lanktree; Philip Weiss, founder of ZN Consulting; former UNESCO Director-General Audrey Azoulay; former U.S. President Barack Obama.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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